

the fans. When dust enters the bearing, it gets mixed with the grease used to lubricate the bearings and starts to thicken. This further leads to heating issues at the bearing. The impeller of current gen fans can be easily pulled out for you to clean the bearing, however, it is important that you lubricate the bearing after you're done. If you have mechanical grease made for fans, then use that, else there's always Vaseline.

Fins

With majority of the air passing over the fins, they tend to get clogged the fastest. Even if the fans attached to the heatsink appear clean, there is a good likelihood that the fins underneath are partially clogged. Using a blower or a can of pressurised gas is the simplest way to clean the fins.



Oh! The humanity!

You should always disconnect the fan from the motherboard before you use a blower since it can generate reverse electricity that could be harmful. Good motherboards have diodes to prevent this reverse flow but if you've got a cheap board, then disconnecting the fan is the safest option.

AIOs

Aside from the issues mentioned above which are also applicable to AIOs. There is the added complexity of the actual 'liquid' part of the AIO that you need to be concerned about. Always check the product page of your AIO to see its 'maintenance-free' period. This is how long you generally do not have to worry about your AIO's loop. Once that's over, your worries begin.